PLAYER HANDOUT — SESSION 0+

Cold Start Syndicate

New Player Primer

> *You woke up 100 years late in the future, pulled from cryo by an unknown patron. Now you run deniable jobs in the House shadow wars while trying to stay human — and stay yourselves.*

New Player Primer — Cold Start Syndicate

Welcome to the table. This document gives you everything you need to make a character and jump into the campaign. Read the first two sections before Session 0+. Skim the rest at your own pace.

The Elevator Pitch

Nova Praxis is a tabletop RPG set in a transhuman, post-scarcity future. Humanity survived the Singularity — barely — and now lives scattered across the solar system under the control of six corporate Houses. Your mind can be backed up, copied, and downloaded into new bodies. Money barely exists; reputation is currency. And underneath the utopian surface, the Houses wage a secret Shadow War for dominance.

Our campaign — Cold Start Syndicate — is this:

> *You woke up 100 years late in this future, pulled from cryo by an unknown patron. Now you run deniable jobs in the House shadow wars while trying to stay human — and stay yourselves.*

Every job has two layers: the obvious contract and the factional agenda underneath. Your choices about identity, loyalty, and methods have real consequences that carry forward.

What You Need to Know About the Setting

THE BIG PICTURE

- **Earth is gone.** The Singularity wiped it out. Humanity lives on stations, colonies, and terraformed worlds across the solar system and a handful of exoplanets.
- **Six Houses run everything.** They replaced governments. Each controls territory, industry, and ideology. They cooperate publicly and sabotage each other constantly.
- **The Coalition** is the thin democratic veneer over the Houses — a United Nations that the Houses mostly ignore when it's inconvenient.
- **Apostates** are people who live outside House and Coalition control. Black marketeers, rebels, refugees. Your crew has ties to this world.

TRANSHUMANITY — THE COOL AND TERRIFYING PART

- **Apotheosis:** A procedure that digitizes your mind. After Apotheosis, your consciousness can be backed up, transferred, and even copied.
- **Sleeves:** Synthetic or biological bodies you can download into. Hardware for your mind. You can upgrade, swap, or lose them.
- **SIMs:** People who exist purely as software — no body at all. They interact with the physical world through drones and mesh networks.
- **Pure:** People who never underwent Apotheosis. Still in their original bodies. Increasingly rare and viewed as either principled or stubborn.
- **Forking:** Copying a mind. The copy is a "fork" — a separate person with your memories up to the split point. This is legally and ethically complicated.
- **Mnemonic Cores:** Your mind's backup drive. If your body dies but your core survives, you can be restored. If it doesn't, you're gone.

WHY THIS MATTERS AT THE TABLE

Identity isn't abstract here. "Who am I?" is an operational question. Characters deal with memory editing, forks of themselves, dying and being restored in new bodies, and the question of whether a copy of you *is* you. The campaign leans into this hard.

The Game System — FATE Quick Version

Nova Praxis runs on a modified version of FATE. If you've never played FATE, here's the core loop.

ROLLING DICE

- Roll **4 Fudge dice** (4dF) — each die shows +1, -1, or 0
- Add your **Skill rank** and any modifiers
- That total is your **Effort**
- Beat the **Difficulty** set by the GM — the margin is your **Shifts**
- **Spin** (3+ Shifts): Something extra good happens
- **Stall** (fail by 3+): Something extra bad happens

ASPECTS — THE HEART OF FATE

Aspects are short phrases that describe something true about your character, the scene, or the world. Examples: *"Cryo-Survivor With Trust Issues"*, *"This Hallway Is On Fire"*, *"Owes a Debt to House Kimura"*.

- **Invoke** an Aspect: Spend 1 Fate Point for +2 to a roll (or a reroll) when the Aspect is relevant
- **Get Compelled:** The GM uses your Aspect to make your life harder — you gain 1 Fate Point
- Aspects are the GM's main tool for creating drama and your main tool for bending the odds

FATE POINTS

- You start each session with your **Refresh** (usually 5, higher for Pure characters)
- Spend them to invoke Aspects or power certain Stunts
- Earn them when your Aspects get compelled against you
- They don't carry between sessions

STRESS AND CONSEQUENCES

When you take a hit — physically, mentally, or digitally:

- **Stress boxes** absorb minor hits and clear after the scene
- **Consequences** absorb bigger hits by giving you a negative Aspect (Mild -2, Moderate -4, Severe -6, Extreme -8)
- If you can't absorb the hit, you're **Taken Out** — the attacker narrates what happens
- You can **Concede** before that point to keep narrative control over your exit

ACTIONS

ACTION	WHAT IT DOES
Test	Roll vs. a fixed difficulty
Contest	Roll vs. another character's roll
Maneuver	Place a temporary Aspect on the scene or target
Assessment	Discover a hidden Aspect
Declaration	Introduce a new fact into the story (costs a Fate Point)
Attack	Deal stress to a target
Block	Prevent a specific action

Building Your Character

STEP 1 — PICK YOUR STATE

This is the biggest choice. It defines your relationship with your own body.

STATE	WHAT IT MEANS	FLAVOR	PERKS
Pure	Original body, no Apotheosis	Principled, unpredictable, off the grid	+2 Refresh, free Carpe Diem stunt, +1 skill, 8 physical skill ranks
SIM	No body — pure software	Digital ghost, drone operator, hacker	Free SIM stunt, SINC bonus, live in virtualities
Sleeved	Digitized mind in a body	Most common, flexible, upgradeable	Physical stats from sleeve, augmentation points, sleeve Aspects

STEP 2 — CHOOSE A SKILL DISTRIBUTION

STYLE	SHAPE	BEST FOR
Specialist	1 at +5, 2 at +4, 2 at +3, 3 at +2, 6 at +1	One standout talent
Expert	3 at +4, 3 at +3, 4 at +2, 6 at +1	Well-rounded competence
Generalist	7 at +3, 8 at +2, 3 at +1	Broad, no weak spots

STEP 3 — PICK YOUR SKILLS

Standard Skills:

SKILL	DOES
Assets	Wealth and black market purchasing power
Cohesion	Mental stability, resisting psychological trauma
Demolitions	Explosives — combat and structural
Diplomacy	Friendly persuasion, negotiation
Education	Book learning — science, history, academic knowledge
H. Engineering	Hardware — build, repair, operate machines
S. Engineering	Software — code, operate CISTs, digital systems
Firearms	Ranged weapons — railguns, coil guns, heavy weapons
Guile	Lying, conning, seduction, haggling
Insight	Gut feelings, reading emotions, mental reflexes
Intimidation	Threats, coercion, interrogation
Melee	Hand-to-hand and melee weapons
Mnemonics	Mind editing, resleeving, forking, AI interaction
House Networking	Contacts among the Houses; starting Rep-Rating
Apostate Networking	Underground and black market contacts
Pilot	Vehicles — ground, air, space
Research	Finding information on the Extranet
Resolve	Willpower, courage, resisting temptation
Strategy	Tactical planning, initiative, reading enemy plans
Stealth	Hiding, pickpocketing, moving unseen

Physical Skills (ranks from your State or Sleeve):

SKILL	DOES
Athletics	Movement, coordination — adds to Physical Stress
Endurance	Toughness, resisting toxins — adds to Physical Stress
Perception	Senses, awareness, noticing things

Special:

SKILL	DOES
SINC	Savant hacking — requires Savant stunt

STEP 4 — PICK STUNTS

You start with **3 Stunts** plus any free ones from your State.

- **Savant** — Unlocks SINC and hacking programs (requires Apotheosis)
- **Drone-Jock** — Cheaper, better drones; bonuses when actively piloting
- **Licensed** — Buy restricted gear legally
- **Battlefield Command** — Move allies tactically
- **Fame** — Celebrity leverage and reputation access
- **Specialty Aspect** — Free invoke once per scene on a specific skill use
- **Skilled** — +1 to any non-physical skill
- **Refreshed** — +1 Refresh (stackable up to 3 times)
- **Transhumanist** — Extra augmentation capacity

STEP 5 — WRITE YOUR ASPECTS

You get 6-7 Aspects using the **ABCDE method:**

SLOT	TYPE	WHAT IT COVERS	EXAMPLE
HC	High Concept	Who you are in one phrase	*"Ghost Pilot with a Death Wish"*
A	Ambition	Your goals and drives	*"I Will Know Who Brought Me Back"*
B	Belief	Your philosophy and values	*"The Only Law Is Consequence"*
C	Connection	Important people, places, debts	*"Owes Everything to a Name I Don't Recognize"*
D	Disadvantage	Your flaw, your obstacle	*"Can't Stop Pulling At Loose Threads"*
E	Expertise	Your methods and approach	*"Violence Is the Language I Speak Fluently"*
7	Physical Trait (Pure) or Savant Disadvantage	State-specific	*"This Body Wasn't Built for This Century"*

Good Aspects are **double-edged** — genuinely useful when invoked, genuinely interesting when compelled.

STEP 6 — SLEEVES (SLEEVED CHARACTERS ONLY)

Starting sleeve cost cap: MAX(Assets, Rep-Rating) + 4.

SLEEVE	COST	PHYS. RANKS	AUG. POINTS	NOTES
Alpha Bio	6	8	2	Budget; Unattractive aspect
Beta Bio	7	9	3	Standard; neutral appearance
Gamma Bio	9	10	4	Enhanced; cosmetic options
Delta Bio	11	11	6	Premium; exceptional genegineering
Epsilon Bio	14	12	8	Top tier

Cybersleeves also exist — talk to Sean about options. They trade biological flexibility for raw power and modularity.

The Existing Crew

You're joining a crew that's been through eight sessions. Here's who's at the table:

CHARACTER	STATE	ROLE	SIGNATURE SKILLS
Aeddarius Crucial	Pure	Strategic commander, political operator	Education +4, House Networking +4, Strategy +4
Grace Pryzbylski	SIM	Digital recon, multi-drone operator	SINC +5, S. Engineering +4, H. Engineering +4
Dustin "Grift" Halloway	Sleeved	Systems infiltrator, social engineer	House Networking +4, Mnemonics +4, S. Engineering +4
Azaria Dawson	Sleeved	Celebrity operative, face	Guile +4, Diplomacy +4, Resolve +4
Kallius	Sleeved	Memory merchant, mnemonic specialist	Mnemonics +5, S. Engineering +4, H. Engineering +4

Note: A sixth crew member — Doc — went SIM and dropped off the grid after Vantage Station. His status is unknown.

WHAT THE CREW IS MISSING

The crew has strong coverage for hacking, social engineering, mnemonic work, and command. What they're short on:

- **Physical presence.** Nobody leads with Athletics or Endurance. A high-endurance brawler or a Pure bruiser would fill a real gap.
- **Stealth.** Infiltration and quiet entry are handled ad-hoc. A dedicated Stealth operator would open new approaches.
- **Demolitions / Hardware.** Kallius and Grace handle hardware, but a true demo specialist or combat engineer would round out tactical options.
- **Pilot.** Doc covered this. With him gone, nobody flies the battle cruiser with confidence.
- **Medical / Biological expertise.** Nobody on the crew has strong Education + Mnemonics for biological scenarios.

That said — play what sounds fun. The crew adapts. These are gaps, not requirements.

Character Suggestions for New Players

These aren't prescriptions. They're starting points that fit the current crew and the campaign's themes.

SUGGESTION 1 — THE SOLDIER

Concept: A cryo-survivor who was military before the Singularity. Woke up to find their entire world gone and adapted the only way they knew how.

State: Sleeved (combat-grade sleeve, high Endurance/Athletics)

Key Skills: Firearms +4, Athletics +4, Strategy +4, Melee +3, Intimidation +3

Stunts: Licensed (carry restricted weapons), Battlefield Command, Specialty Aspect (under fire)

High Concept: *"Last Soldier of a War Nobody Remembers"*

Disadvantage: *"Still Fighting Like the Old Rules Apply"*

Why it fits: The crew has intelligence assets and social operators but no reliable frontline fighter. Someone with Firearms +4 and a combat sleeve changes the calculus in every physical confrontation. Strategy overlap with Aeddarius creates natural command tension — who's actually running the op?

SUGGESTION 2 — THE PILOT

Concept: Someone who lived and breathed flight before the Singularity and found that skill still translates. They move between the real world and virtual cockpits like most people move between rooms.

State: SIM or Sleeved

Key Skills: Pilot +5, S. Engineering +4, Perception +4, Stealth +3, H. Engineering +3

Stunts: Drone-Jock, Savant (optional — makes them a SIM rival to Grace), Specialty Aspect (in the cockpit)

High Concept: *"Born to Fly, Forced to Walk"*

Disadvantage: *"The Real World Is Just Bad Lag"*

Why it fits: Doc left a vacancy. Someone needs to fly the battle cruiser — a ship that size is a liability without a pilot. A SIM pilot would create interesting dynamic with Grace (two mesh-native crew members navigating the same space). A Sleeved pilot brings a physicality Grace lacks.

SUGGESTION 3 — THE FIXER

Concept: Someone who survived the century gap by being useful to people who needed things done quietly. A networker, information broker, or black market operator with roots in the

apostate underground.

State: Sleeved (low-profile sleeve, nothing flashy)

Key Skills: Apostate Networking +5, Guile +4, Research +4, Stealth +4, Assets +3

Stunts: Fame (underground version — well-known in the right circles), Specialty Aspect (reading a room), Skilled +1 (Guile)

High Concept: *"Everyone Owes Me a Favor, I Owe Everyone a Secret"*

Disadvantage: *"My Past Has More Reach Than My Future"*

Why it fits: The crew runs jobs in both Coalition and apostate spaces, but their Apostate Networking is thin. This character opens doors Aeddarius and Grift can't reach and creates natural dramatic tension — they have relationships on both sides of the law. Stealth gives the crew a quiet-entry specialist they've been missing.

SUGGESTION 4 — THE GHOST

Concept: A Pure who shouldn't logically be alive. Someone the records show as dead — or who never existed in the Coalition's database. A walking blind spot in the surveillance state.

State: Pure

Key Skills: Stealth +5, Resolve +4, Melee +4, Insight +3, Research +3

Stunts: Carpe Diem (free — Pure), Refreshed, Specialty Aspect (operating off-mesh)

High Concept: *"The Coalition Thinks I'm Dead. Let's Keep It That Way."*

Disadvantage: *"Can't Ask for Help Without Exposing Myself"*

Why it fits: The crew operates in a surveillance state where every transaction, face, and movement is logged. A Pure character with no mesh footprint can go places nobody else on the crew can. High Resolve complements the psychological pressure arcs the campaign runs. The independence/isolation tension with a crew that relies heavily on mesh communication is rich dramatic material. Aeddarius is already Pure — two Pure characters creates a natural in-crew dynamic around what "being human" actually means in this century.

What's Happened So Far — Spoiler Lite

The crew woke up from cryo owing their existence to a mysterious patron. Since then:

- They survived a crisis on Europa Station, a rogue SIM siege, and a corporate cover-up
- They discovered that a faction called **Chimera** is orchestrating events behind the scenes
- A woman named **Valare** holds critical information — her backup fork is alive, traumatized, and refusing to come in
- An operative named **Kestrel** has been deployed to clean up all evidence — including the crew
- The crew has a battle cruiser and a lot of enemies

Your characters don't need to know any of this. Session 0+ will establish how you connect to the crew. Sean will work with you on that.

Session 0+ Checklist

- [ ] Read this primer
- [ ] Think about what sounds fun — combat? social? hacking? weird?
- [ ] Pick a State (Pure / SIM / Sleeved) — or come with 2-3 ideas to narrow down
- [ ] Draft a High Concept and Disadvantage Aspect — rough is fine
- [ ] Look at the character suggestions — steal freely, riff on them, or ignore entirely
- [ ] We'll build the rest together at the table

Don't stress about getting everything perfect. Session 0+ is exactly for this — we'll walk through it together and make sure your character fits the world and the crew.

Quick Reference — The FATE Ladder

RANK	NAME
+8	Legendary
+7	Epic
+6	Fantastic
+5	Superb
+4	Great
+3	Good
+2	Fair
+1	Average
0	Mediocre
-1	Poor
-2	Terrible